

PART 4: THE ADVENTURE

Beginning the Adventure

When the players have rolled up their characters and bought their equipment, the DM will describe the background of the adventure. This might include information about the place the characters start from, the names of any NPC companions or retainers they will have, and some rumors about the dungeon the party is going to explore.

Party Size and Composition

It is not wise to adventure alone, for the monsters which may be encountered are numerous. It is much safer to go adventuring with a group of people who can help and protect each other. The best size for an adventure party is 6-8 characters, enough to handle the challenges which will be faced, but not too many to become disorganized or to ruin chances to surprise the monsters. It is smart for an adventure party to contain a variety of character classes to gain the benefits of different class abilities. Fighters are best for fighting, while clerics are able to fight, but also have several spells to help cure wounds and aid in fighting. Magic-users are good thinkers and problem solvers and have powerful spells; thieves are useful for opening locked doors and scouting ahead. Elves, dwarves and halflings all have special powers which can prove helpful to have along as well.

Most DMs allow a player only one character at a time. Sometimes a person may play more than one character at a time, such as when only a few persons are playing. The players (and the DM) should try to keep any characters played by one person from becoming too close (passing magical treasures between themselves, borrowing money from each other, and so forth). There is no reason for characters run by the same player to be any more friendly with each other than with characters run by different players. The DM may allow a player character to hire companions (see **Retainers**, page B21) to add to the size of a party.

Organizing a Party

Before entering a dungeon, the players should arrange their characters in a "marching order". A "marching order" is the order of position in which the characters in a party explore a dungeon; who's scouting in front, searching in the middle, and guarding the rear. Different marching orders may be used when opening doors, searching rooms, fighting combat, and so forth. The most common marching order is to explore in a column of two-by-two though this may vary in corridors of different widths. Characters who can wear full armor might be placed to guard the front and back of the party, while magic-users and thieves might be placed in the middle of the party, ready to use their skills when needed.

THE CALLER: One player should be chosen to tell the DM about the plans and actions of the party. This player is the **caller**. The players may tell the DM what their characters are doing, but the game runs more smoothly when the **caller** relays the information. The **caller** should be sure to check with each member of the party before announcing any actions (such as "We'll turn right" or "The thief will check for traps"). The **caller** is usually a character with a high Charisma score, and should be near the front of the party, where the character would be able to see what the DM describes.

MAPPING: One player should draw a map of the dungeon as it is explored. This player is called the **mapper**. Normal movement includes the time spent exploring, measuring and mapping the dungeon.

Maps are drawn to help players visualize the area their characters are exploring and to provide a record of sections of a dungeon they have already explored. A good mapper should listen closely to the DM in order to draw a good representation of the dungeon. It is most important to record proper directions, shape, and approximate size, rather than spending a lot of time determining exact measurements and filling in minute details. It is also a good idea to make brief notes about where traps, monsters, and unusual features are encountered. A map should be simple and easy to read.

FIGURES: If miniature figures are used to represent the characters, the players should choose figures which look like their characters, and should make sure that the DM knows which miniatures represent which characters. The miniature figures should be lined up in the same order as the marching order. When special situations occur, the players should change the position of their figures as they desire. File cards with names on them, pawns, and other markers may be used instead of miniatures, or the marching order may simply be written on a piece of paper.

TIME: Time in D&D adventures is given in turns of ten minutes each. A turn is not a measure of real time, but is a measure of how much a character can do within a given amount of time. A character may explore and map an area equal to his or her movement rate in one turn. It also takes a turn for a character to search a 10'x10' area, for a thief to check an item for traps, to rest or to load a bag with treasure. The DM should decide how long other actions that characters might try will take.

MOVEMENT: In the D&D, rules movement is given in the number of feet a character may move in one turn. All characters are able to move 120' or feet in one turn when exploring a dungeon. This is only a base movement rate used to compare the speed of the characters with the monsters which are encountered and to determine both encounter and running speeds. Encounter and running movement is much faster and is given as the number of feet the character can move in one round. Encounter movement is determined by dividing the base movement rate by 3, while running speed is equal to the base movement rate in rounds.

A base movement rate of 120' in ten minutes may seem slow, but it assumes that the players are mapping carefully, searching, and trying to be quiet. It also takes into account the generally "dark and dingy" conditions of the dungeon in which characters are adventuring.

The DM may wish to allow characters to move faster when traveling through areas they are familiar with. The DM will also have to determine movement rates for special situations, such as for swimming, climbing or crawling, and for crossing special areas, such as slippery ground, steep hills, broken rocks and mud.

RESTING: After moving for 5 turns, the party must rest for 1 turn. One turn in 6 (one each hour of the adventure) must be spent resting. If characters do not rest, they have a penalty of -1 on all "to hit" and damage rolls until they do rest.

SCALE MOVEMENT: If miniature figures are used, the actual movement of the characters can be represented at the scale of one inch equals ten feet. A movement rate of 60' per turn would mean that a miniature figure would move 6 inches in that turn. Scale movement is useful for moving the figures on a playing surface (such as a table).